

Philadelphia science museum closes as supporters seek a way back

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A Philadelphia museum that has introduced generations of children to dinosaurs and nature has closed to visitors. Families crowded into the Academy of Natural Sciences Museum during its final weeks in September.

The Academy was founded in 1812 and opened to the public in 1828. In 1868, it became the first place in the world to display a dinosaur skeleton. Its exhibits also included live animals and scenes showing mammals in their **habitats**.

Drexel University took financial responsibility for the Academy in 2011. The university says costs rose and visitor numbers fell after the pandemic. The museum had already reduced its hours and cancelled its 2026 summer camp.

Supporters want to bring it back. A **petition** to keep the museum open gathered more than 114,000 signatures. Shortly before the September 30 closing date, the William Penn Foundation offered **funding** for one year. This **temporary** help could provide time to seek a lasting solution.

Drexel says it is exploring that offer, but reopening would need a plan to support the museum over time. Philadelphia's city council also plans public **hearings** to examine the closure and possible solutions.

The Academy holds more than 19 million scientific **specimens**, or samples used for study. Drexel says students and researchers will keep access to the collection. Public access remains unclear.

Word Treasure

habitats -- Places where animals or plants naturally live.

petition -- A written request that people sign to show support.

funding -- Money provided to support an activity or organization.

temporary -- Lasting for a limited time.

hearings -- Meetings held to gather information and listen to people.

specimens -- Samples used for study.

Break it down

Introduces the museum's closure and families' final visits.

Describes the Academy's history and exhibits.

Explains Drexel's account of costs and attendance.

Reports the petition, funding offer and planned hearings.

Ends with collection access and uncertainty for the public.

Why it matters

The closure affects a place where children learned about dinosaurs and nature. Reopening and future public access remain uncertain.

Test what you remember

1. In which city is the museum?

- ☐ (A) Baltimore
- ☐ (B) Boston
- ☐ (C) Pittsburgh
- ☐ (D) Philadelphia

2. What did the Academy first display in 1868?

- ☐ (A) A collection of paintings
- ☐ (B) A model of a spaceship
- ☐ (C) A display of engines
- ☐ (D) A dinosaur skeleton

3. What does Drexel say happened after the pandemic?

- ☐ (A) Costs fell and visitor numbers fell.
- ☐ (B) Costs fell and visitor numbers rose.
- ☐ (C) Costs rose and visitor numbers rose.
- ☐ (D) Costs rose and visitor numbers fell.

4. How long would the foundation's offered funding last?

- ☐ (A) Ten years
- ☐ (B) One year
- ☐ (C) One month
- ☐ (D) Five years

5. What does Philadelphia's city council plan to do?

- ☐ (A) Organize new summer camps
- ☐ (B) Build new dinosaur exhibits
- ☐ (C) Take over museum tours
- ☐ (D) Hold public hearings

6. Who does Drexel say will keep access to the collection?

- ☐ (A) Students and researchers
- ☐ (B) Athletes and coaches
- ☐ (C) Tourists and tour guides
- ☐ (D) Shoppers and shop owners

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: D 2: D 3: D 4: B 5: D 6: A

Questions to think about

1. Drexel University: Says costs rose and attendance fell after the pandemic, and that reopening would require a long-term financial plan.

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):